

Figure 4.9 *Shah-i Mashhad* madrasa: *north entrance, detail of inscription. © Photograph Bernt Glatzer c. 1970.*

recitation of *Shahada* was tantamount to full Islamic conversion (see above) – likely bypassed even the limited, mnemonic literacy of other pre-modern Islamic populations.[54] Such a loophole would have been all the more necessary among people of rural, nomadic, and/or transhumant lifestyles, largely living beyond the urban settlements of what is now Afghanistan. Thus, royal Shansabani involvement in the sophisticated epigraphic and decorative programs of their monumental commissions was conceivably secondary to that of the literate, even well-read advisors and eventual users of the buildings. Execution of the designs by generationally trained artisans, specialized in various aspects of building and decoration, surely contributed a formative element as well.[55]

This is not to say that, as patrons of "civic" architecture, the Shansabani sultans and their families and associates made absolutely no mark on their foundations or the latter's complex epigraphic programs. But it must be borne in mind that at least the Shansabani family members – if not also their nobles and other associates – certainly differed from their most proximate contemporaries. The Ghaznavids, for example, whose scions had been thoroughly educated in Sunni Islam and steeped in Persianate culture, were surely discerning patrons probably even intervening in architectural and epigraphic details.[56] The Shansabanis, though also preoccupied with consolidating and expanding an imperial presence (like the Ghaznavids), nonetheless had come to an *overt* embrace of Islamic socio-religious mores and Persianate ceremonial